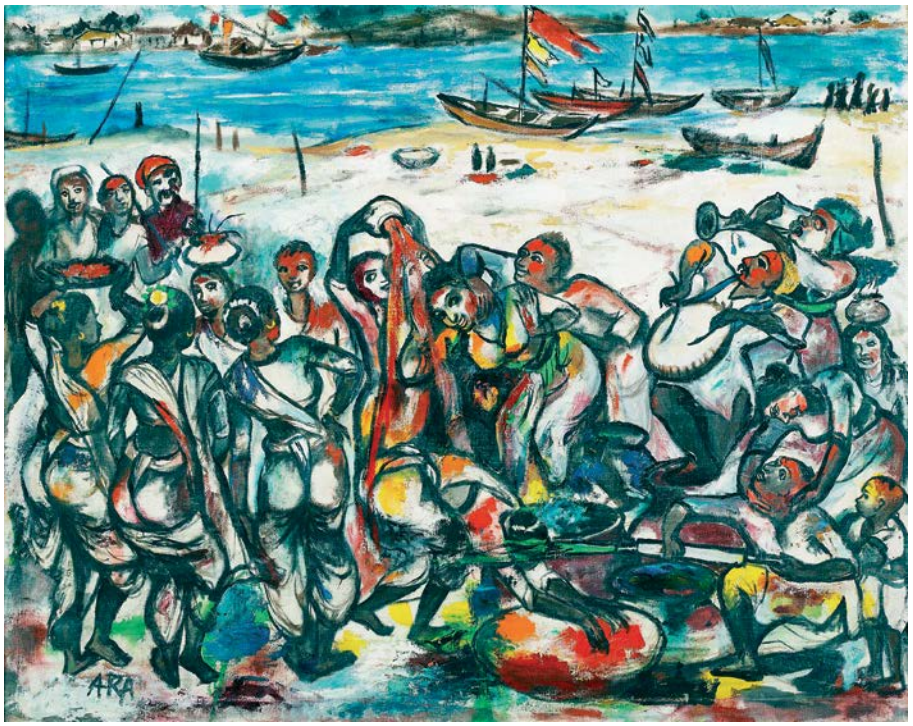


ART

COMING UP FOR AIR

The **Air India art collection** can finally be viewed at a landmark exhibition at the National Gallery of Modern Art, Mumbai



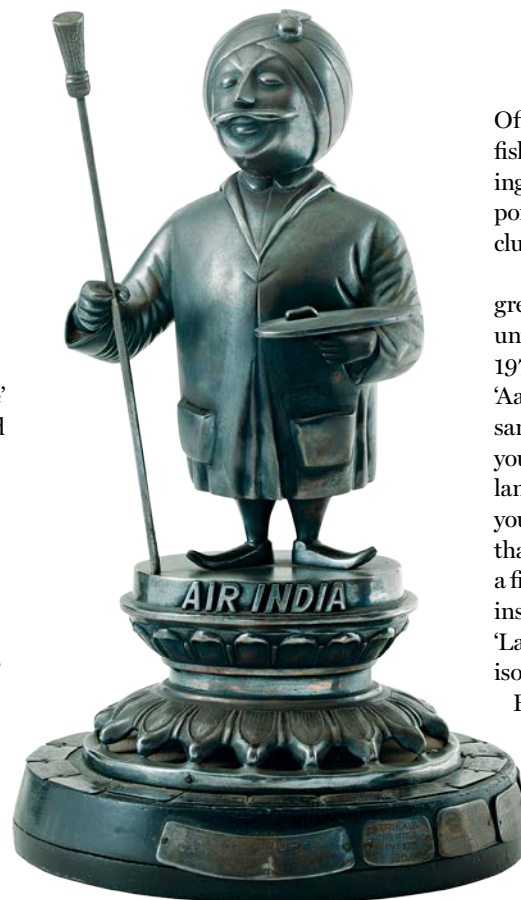
I

It can't get more Indian than this. The first exhibit is a glorious Ganesha. Opposite that, a familiar turbaned Maharaja bows his head, ushering you into the high-ceilinged foyer of Mumbai's National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA). It seems apt—we're here to see the *Maharaja's Treasure: Select Works of Art from the Famed Air India Collection* after all.

The once revered, then beleaguered, and recently resuscitated airline is an Indian icon. Over eight decades of its existence, it has also acquired an enviable collection of art (some specially commissioned). Now, the artworks, which were hitherto accessible only to patrons and visitors to airport lounges across the world, are available for everyone to savour.

Nazneen Banu, director, NGMA, says the collection has been handed over to the culture ministry and will be housed at the NGMA for posterity. Her team chose 200 of the thousands of artworks offered, based on their relevance as a showcase of contemporary art in India and how well they have weathered time. The curation is not just a clustering of all work by a single artist or a decade, but has a gently flowing theme that takes you on a voyage of discovery. The sun, be it G.R. Santosh's spiritual take on 'Surya' and his horse-drawn chariot, or B. Prabha's glowing orb of 'Sunrise' from 1979, or many others, is followed by an equine theme, most famously in the magnificent canvas by M.F. Husain that dominates an entire wall of this hall.

At the next level, the narrative gets more layered. Women are the focal point here, with Arpana Caur's oil on canvases titled 'Day' and 'Night' from 1997 speaking volumes of their daily dilemmas and contributions.



Off to one side is a section dedicated to fisherwomen. Sculptures complementing each theme serve as a subtle pivotal point as we move from one thought cluster to the next.

At the top of the stairway, we are greeted by a jaw-dropping duo—an untitled V.S. Gaitonde abstract from 1977 on the left and S.H. Raza's 'Aanchal Verse Sardar Jafri' from the same year on the right. One draws you into its depths through a complex landscape, while the other broadens your horizons through vibrant details that seem familiar yet ephemeral. It's a fitting welcome to a floor filled with inspiring abstracts. Sarabjeet Singh's 'Ladakh 1' evokes a sense of peaceful isolation; A.A. Raiba's 'White Town/ Black Town' blends half-timbered European homes and terracotta